



THE CRUSADES

The city of Jerusalem and the Holy Land of Palestine (now including Israel and Jordan) are special to people of three faiths—Jews, Muslims, and Christians. Nine hundred years ago, the first of a series of wars broke out over control of Jerusalem. In 1095, European Christians set out to take the city, then ruled by Muslims. The Europeans were called crusaders from the French word *croisade*, meaning “carrying a cross.”

In 1099, after four years of struggle, the crusaders captured Jerusalem and held it for nearly one hundred years. Then it was recaptured by a great Muslim leader called Saladin. More crusades followed, but none was successful. However, the returning crusaders brought many new objects and ideas back to Europe.



Stronghold

The crusaders built strong castles in the Arab style to defend the land they had captured. This is Krak des Chevaliers in Syria.



Over his armor, the knight is wearing a cross—the sign of a crusader.

